

Humorous face-threatening acts: Humor as strategy[☆]

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Abstract

This study attempts to analyze the ways in which some Face-Threatening Acts (FTAs, Brown and Levinson, 1978) are implemented in joking. Like 'regular' FTAs, humorous FTAs may equally be effected in on-record, redressed, and off-record modes. When redressed, the humorous FTA can be administered by violating the Speaker's or Hearer's positive face within the frame of reference of negative politeness, or, alternately, by violating the Speaker's or Hearer's negative face within the frame of reference of positive politeness.

Strategic advantages of the speaker over the hearer involved in the humorous act are discussed. The last section deals with the strategic advantages of self-denigrating humor.

1. Introduction

Some acts, whether verbal or non-verbal, intrinsically threaten the face of the participants involved in the human interaction. These acts may threaten the positive face of S(peaker) or H(earer), i.e. violate the wish of each participant that his/her wishes be desirable to at least some others, or violate the negative face of S or H, i.e. the wish of each participant that his/her actions be unimpeded by others. Acts threatening the positive face of H are, for instance, a negative evaluation of aspects of H's face such as disapproval or criticism of him/her, or showing S's carelessness in regard to H's positive face, such as expressing contempt or embarrassing him/her. Instances of acts threatening the negative face of H may include S ordering or requesting something from H or pressuring him or her into doing things according to S's wish. An example of acts threatening the positive face of S are apologies or expressions of self-humiliation; an example of an act threatening S's negative face is making an excuse. Usually, S will want to minimize the impact of the Face-Threatening Act (FTA) by means of redressing strategies (Brown and Levinson,

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1978). However, when humorous acts such as joking take place, S often does not attempt to minimize the FTAs. On the contrary, he/she may look for ways of performing them, and H on his/her part often seems to accept them, whether willingly or not. It seems that in such cases S and H tacitly agree that face demands be suspended for the sake of the other interest, which is 'to get a laugh'.

2. Humorous FTAs

FTAs may be performed on-record, with or without redressive action, or off-record (Brown and Levinson, 1978). The same applies to humorous FTAs, namely laugh-evoking FTAs. Not only may the content of the humorous FTA threaten the participants' faces, but the very fact of joking may threaten both the faces of S and of H, with the result discussed later on.

2.1. *Bald-on-record*

Non-humorous FTAs which are implemented in a bald-on-record fashion are direct, unambiguous and concise. Although apparently they bear the maximal face threat, this strategy may be selected to minimize the face threat when there is consent between S and H as to the legitimacy of this act. Two cases serve to substantiate this: when the danger to H's face is really small, or when S is vastly superior to H (Brown and Levinson, 1978). Similarly, the humorous bald-on-record FTA, while conveying the derogatory sense loud and clear, may in fact minimize the face threat, in that it can easily be dismissed along the lines of: 'He/she could not *really* mean that ...' As La Fave and Mannell put it:

"... the irony of irony is that an extreme insult is less insulting than a mild insult, since the former is less likely to be taken literally and more probably cognitively restructured as 'He's only joking'." (1976: 121)

Comic invective may serve as an example of a humorous bald-on-record FTA. The politician's public face may seem to be threatened by the humorous FTA directed against him/her, yet the threat is minimized to a certain extent, inasmuch as the insulting content is not taken literally, and is moreover taken as a facet of that politician's notability (Nevo-Eshkol, 1988). The words of the late Israeli Minister of Finance, Mr. Ehrlich, can serve as an example of the humorous bald-on-record FTA. He himself being a member of the Liberal Party, he made use of the last name of another member of the party, one Mr. Pat. He would say:

In our party we have a Pat, an Antipath [referring to one Mr. Sharir known for his unpleasant personality], and a Psychopath [referring to one Mr. Modai, who was famous for his weird behavior].

2.2. *Redressive action*

The redressive action for FTAs usually involves forms of politeness whose indirectness serves to minimize the threat. The following section deals with the affinity of politeness conventions to those of humor, and examines the use of politeness conventions in manipulating humorous FTAs.

2.2.1. *Humor and politeness*

Brown and Levinson (1978) regard joking as one of the positive politeness techniques, i.e. as a strategy used to minimize the threat to one's positive face. Positive politeness realizations are ways of minimizing social distance. Joking may serve this purpose, for example when S is joking in order to 'put H at ease'. Joking then is meant to generate feelings of familiarity and friendship by alluding to S's and H's shared background knowledge and values. Another kind of humorous expressions aiming at maintaining both S's and H's positive faces are 'inside jokes', which claim common attitudes and empathy between S and H, with an additional touch of superiority feeling in both towards the uninitiated. Also, as Murphy and Pollio (1973) have shown empirically, humor is enjoyed more in the company of friends than among strangers. So, joking that 'puts H at ease', 'inside jokes' and friendly joking are all instances showing how humor can contribute to the preservation of one's positive face.

On the social level, so-called 'constructive humor' helps to maintain the positive face of a group (Martineau, 1972) in that it fosters consensus and solidarity, reinforces intragroup cohesiveness, strengthens personal ties among the participants, relieves tensions, and lubricates social relations.

Intuitively speaking, humor is closer to the positive politeness techniques which foster friendship and familiarity than to the negative politeness of non-imposition embodied in the rules of formal etiquette. Humor is associated with what is unexpected and surprising, whereas the official rules of behavior, the so-called 'good manners', are predictable and rigorous. Etiquette is supposed to restrict human spontaneous behavior (Martin, 1983), whereas one of humor's major functions is to liberate (Mindess, 1971). And yet, some of the aspects of humor resemble some aspects of etiquette.

In today's Western culture, both humor and etiquette are considered to be of minor importance, yet both have high social desirability. Both are built upon conventions. For example, one of the conventions of joke telling is that S should not laugh while the joke is being narrated, whereas H is expected to behave cooperatively, in the sense that, if asked in the middle of a joke: 'And you know what this guy told her?', he should answer: 'What?', rather than: 'How many guesses do I have?' Both etiquette and humor deal mainly with appearances, rather than with morals or the pursuit of truth. We know that things are not what they appear to be, and that utterances are to be neither decoded literally nor verified. For example, H who on hearing a joke declares: 'That's impossible', shows that he/she fails to understand what humor is. The same applies to etiquette:

“ ‘Why did she ask me how I feel if she didn’t want to hear about what I’ve been through?’ ...

... ‘I’m not going to address him as ‘Dear’ or sign myself ‘Yours truly’ or ‘Sincerely’, when he’s certainly not dear to me and I’m not truly or sincerely or any other way his ...’ Miss Manners cannot believe that they honestly don’t understand what a conventional phrase is. She thinks that they want to strip these remarks of their usefulness and then laugh at their nakedness.” (Martin, 1983: 170)

Both humor and etiquette depend on rules. In the case of etiquette, these rules are expected to be observed; in that of humor, to be transgressed; but in both they have to be known and accepted, in order for their observance – or non-observance – to have sense and offer pleasure (Dolitsky, 1992: 36). Humor gains its liberating power only when the breaking of rules is local and temporary, while the sane world with its fixed rules is all the time waiting around the corner. Rules of etiquette serve social functions similar to those of humor: to foster consensus, to control conflicts, and to help maintain the social order.

The procedure of joke telling often reflects, rather than abolishes, the hierarchical pecking order – people of superior status tell jokes ‘down’ to their inferiors, while the members of lower status in hierarchical organizations refrain from telling jokes ‘up’ (Coser, 1959; Neitz, 1980; Smeltzer and Leap, 1988). Joking is also considered as a feature characterizing the language of the group in power, e.g. men use it more than women do (Cashion, 1985; DuBrin, 1991). Polite language, on the other hand, is attributed to the weaker group, in this case women (Brown and Levinson, 1978; Cashion, 1985).

Negative politeness rules are used in order to promote distance and respect. Joking, too, can be used as a strategy for creating psychological distance. This has been observed in dynamic group encounters, where the use of humor in their progressive stages was assessed as obstructing the group’s growth in that it prevented feelings of intimacy and closeness from developing among the participants. In this respect, humor functions as a defense mechanism (Ziv, 1984). Some aspects of etiquette are meant to serve the same purpose. The high degree of indirectness which characterizes both humor and etiquette allows for minimizing FTAs, while expressing ambiguous utterances. On the other hand, this also allows for ambiguity, which may lead to misunderstandings when unintentional gaps of interpretations between S and H occur; alternatively, it may lead to abusive procedures, if such gaps are deliberately being manipulated by one of the parties. (This aspect will be further elaborated on in section 3, ‘Humor as strategy’.)

The breach of rules involved in the creation of humor motivated the former Queen of Etiquette, Emily Post, to treat humor displays rather sceptically. At the beginning of the century she wrote:

“It is pleasant to have the ability to see the funny side of things ... and still there isn’t a day that one doesn’t see a sense of humor displayed when it should be suppressed ... Keep your sense of humor in check.” (1922: 108)

2.2.2. Humorous FTA and politeness

Positive and negative politeness presuppose different distances between S and H. In the frame of reference of positive politeness, this distance is small; in negative politeness, it is large. Positive politeness fosters friendship and familiarity, while observing conventions of negative politeness breeds respect.

“Positive and negative politeness are, to a large extent ... mutually exclusive strategies.” (Brown and Levinson, 1978: 275)

I want to argue that some humorous FTAs can be administered by manipulating the distance between S and H. A humorous FTA may be performed by violating the negative face within the frame of reference of positive politeness, or alternately, by violating the positive face within the frame of reference of negative politeness. Here, the humorous FTA seems to present an inverted logic: in the non-humorous mode of communication, politeness strategies serve to redress an FTA, whereas in humorous communication, politeness strategies serve as *an alibi* for administering an FTA.

Following are two examples of humorous FTAs originating from a violation of H's negative face, with positive politeness conventions being observed:

- (i) A group of co-workers sat in a restaurant. One of them turned to another and said: “I have a joke, let's say it's about you, Ricardo. It goes like this: ‘A certain man died and was condemned to hell. On arrival he was told that everybody was punished according to the crimes of his former life. So he saw Casanova dancing with an extremely homely girl, and Don Juan embracing a witch. Suddenly he saw our Ricardo – with Jane Fonda! ‘How come?’, he asked. ‘He is her punishment’, came the answer’.”

An utterance such as this apparently presents a tremendous FTA to Ricardo's negative face, by the implied analogy between him and the witch, after we had been deceitfully led to believe that the analogy is between him and Casanova. On the other hand, the overall atmosphere in this group is that of positive politeness, as promoted by the use of the personal pronoun (‘our Ricardo’). Then a slip was made towards negative politeness conventions by asking for Ricardo's permission to let the joke be about him. However, S did not wait for Ricardo's answer, but assumed that the permission was granted, which restored relations based on positive politeness conventions. Thus, the canned joke (refreshed by inserting the name of one of the participants), which could otherwise have been interpreted by Ricardo as a downright affront (himself being presented as an epitome of unmanliness), passed for humor.

- (ii) One of the guests invited for a friendly celebration had inadvertently broken a glass. After a momentary silence a tragic voice of another guest was heard: ‘Why did you have to do this, David?’
A burst of laughter followed.

David's negative face has been threatened by the assumption conveyed by the other guest, that he had deliberately committed his *faux pas*. However, the frame of reference was that of positive politeness, and thus the utterance of the other guest was decoded as humorous.

An opposite way of introducing the humorous FTA is by means of violating one's positive face within the frame of reference of negative politeness conventions. For example:

- (iii) "Conservative columnist William F. Buckley once received a very abusive letter from a Dr. Prickman, to which he responded: 'My friends call me Buck. What do your friends call you?' " (Telushkin, 1992: 88)

The positive face of Dr. Prickman has been threatened by the allusion to the derogatory sense attached to his name. This was performed within the frame of reference of negative politeness, as required by the situation in which official correspondence between two public personas takes place.

To humorous FTAs emerging from violating H's positive face within a negative politeness frame belong also those cases in which employers humorously administer disciplinary remarks to their employees so as to allow the deviant H to

"... acknowledge the incongruity of his behavior, correct his behavior, and rejoin the group without 'losing face'." (Martineau, 1972: 117)

The same is the case in 'joking relationships' described by Radcliffe-Brown, where H refrains from taking offense out of respect for S. 'Joking relationships' are defined as

"... a relation between two persons in which one is by custom permitted, and in some instances required, to tease or make fun of the other, who in turn is required to take no offense." (1940: 90)

If one is not sure whether positive or negative politeness conventions are in order, humor may be used as a means of *sub rosa* communication, to gauge the feelings of others (Wilson, 1979).

2.3. Off-record

The prescription for a *non-humorous* off-record FTA is 'Be indirect'; this strategy involves a violation of Grice's Maxims. It is interesting to note how much the techniques involved in performing a non-humorous, off-record FTA resemble those of creating regular humorous utterances. Brown and Levinson (1978) list the following: Hinting, presupposing, understating, overstating, tautology, irony, metaphors, ambiguities, contradictions, rhetorical questions, vagueness and incompleteness, overgeneralization, and use of ellipsis. An off-record communicative act is done in such a way that it is not possible to attribute just one clear communicative intention to the act. An off-record, humorous FTA seems to be a case in which H feels insulted by S's words, whereas S insists that he was 'only joking'. For example,

- (iv) A couple of years ago, Teddy Kollek, the near-eternal mayor of Jerusalem, known also for his quick temper, was annoyed by one of his citizens to the point that he shouted at the man, loud and clear, and in the presence of other people: ‘You can kiss my foot!’.¹ The insulted citizen sued him. In court, Teddy claimed, as his defence: ‘I only gave him a suggestion, he didn’t have to do it!’.

The next section will show how humorous FTAs can be manipulated as part of the strategy of interaction.

3. Humor as strategy

Joking may be considered as an agreeable pastime, but it can also be analyzed from the point of view of the pay-offs to the participants involved in the interaction (Berne, 1964). In this, the humorous behavior can be regarded as part of a personal communicative strategy (Zajdman, 1994).

3.1. *The humorous communication mode*

Although ‘a joke is a cooperative enterprise’ (Raskin, 1985: 104), the principles of humorous communication violate Grice’s (1975) cooperative principle of communication. Humor is not the only case where Grice’s Maxims are transgressed against. Coulthard says:

‘... there will always be occasions when a speaker decides to ‘quietly and unostentatiously violate a maxim’ – he may lie, he may not give as much of the relevant information as he could, or he may, like the Delphic oracle, offer utterances which are only later seen to be ambiguous ...’ (1985: 31)

In humor, however, S does not violate Grice’s maxim ‘quietly and unostentatiously’. As I have argued elsewhere (Zajdman, 1992), the humorous mode of communication is not a simple switch from *bona fide* (BF) mode of communication to *non-bona-fide* (NBF) mode (Raskin, 1985). The *bona-fide-cum-humor* ((BF(H))) mode differs from the NBF mode (as in lying or otherwise obscuring the sense), in that the ‘covering move’ (Goffman, 1970) involved in the humorous act aims at being uncovered. In many other instances of the NBF mode, S may gain advantage over H by having, and using, knowledge that H does not possess. In humor, this does not seem to be the case. In a felicitously accomplished two-party humorous act, both S and H are supposed to perform mode switching, so that H gets a feeling of participating in ‘fair play’, being ‘frontally attacked’, rather than fooled behind his/her back. Humor often adds to this feeling of ‘fairness’, in that sometimes, though not always, S uses humor for humor’s own sake, namely only in order to produce laughter, not having further goals; S may simply be jokey by nature, or in a jokey mood.

¹ It wasn’t a foot.

Therefore his/her use of humor may seem benign to H, who does not feel used or threatened by being the butt of a joke.

3.2. *The FTA aspects of the joking activity*

3.2.1. *For the speaker*

Any joking activity presents a potential FTA to S in that it contains the risk of his joke falling flat. Another sort of FTA arising from humor is when S practices self-denigrating humor; this will be dealt with in the last section of this paper. Usually, the joking activity is carried out under conditions of uncertainty. The joke may 'fall flat' when there is a disagreement in joke appreciation between S and H. This disagreement may result from H's incomplete switch from BF to BF(H) mode of communication, as mentioned earlier. Many reasons may cause H's failure to perform a switch, for example his or her personality structure, a cognitive deficiency, temporary mood, psychological resistance towards S and so on. What may be perceived as humorous to one person may be considered inappropriate or offensive by another (Smeltzer and Leap, 1988). Also, the appreciation of offensiveness of jokes may change according to one's role in the humorous act; Johnson (1990) found that Ss who rated *themselves* as tellers of offensive jokes attributed far less congruence between jokes and their attitudes than Ss who rate *others* as tellers of jokes.

3.2.2. *For the hearer*

Any joking activity presents a potential FTA for H in that it involves the risk of his/her 'not getting the joke'. This makes any act of telling a joke, regardless of its content, a form of aggression, however mild, in that it challenges those cognitive and emotional dispositions of H which constitute his/her so-called 'sense of humor'. As to the content, the danger of 'being laughed at' is known to be one of the most powerful social threats. Bergson's (1901) theory of laughter is based on the assumption that in order to avoid being laughed at, the individual behaves according to the norms of behavior of the group of his reference. Thus, laughter serves as a social corrective. The only example of being laughed at which is interpreted as a saving, rather than losing, face activity takes place in the professional context; the clown saves his face when being laughed at, whereas not being laughed at means a disgrace for him. Canned jokes may also pose FTAs to H, according to the extent to which the symbolic transformations achieved within the joke's boundaries can be transposed into 'real world' relationships. It is interesting that the personal FTA posed by the joke sometimes achieves supremacy over the FTA posed by the joke to its formal butt, as in the following event:

- (v) Rebecca used to complain about her workplace. Once she and her husband were attending a social gathering at their neighbors' house. After listening to her endless wailing, her husband (S1) said: "You think *she's* suffering? *I'm* suffering having to listen to her complaints every day!". Upon this another neighbor (S2) told the following joke: "What is the difference between Christian and Jewish nurses? After a night shift the Christian nurse says: 'What a

terrible night did the patient have’, and the Jewish nurse says: ‘What a terrible night did I have’. ”

Although the canned joke told in this event is formally ethnic and mysogenous, because its butt is a Jewish woman, S2 determined its relevance to the situation on grounds of the personal FTA for S1 decoded from the joke, which had nothing to do with ethnicity or gender issues. Actually, when a humorous FTA has been performed, one out of four possible configurations between S and H concerning the appreciation of S’s intentions may arise:

Speaker’s intention	Hearer’s interpretation	Speaker’s expectation	Hearer’s reaction
(a) Meaning offense	Taking offense	Insult	Insult
(b) Meaning offense	Not taking offense	Insult	Amusement
(c) Not meaning offense	Taking offense	Amusement	Insult
(d) Not meaning offense	Not taking offense	Amusement	Amusement

Configurations (a) and (d) present agreement of appreciation between S and H, therefore the communication act is felicitously accomplished. In configuration (b) and (c), there is disagreement between the participants. Configuration (b) does not pose a special problem; S simply has to try harder. Configuration (c) opens up an avenue for misunderstandings and abuse; S may not be fully aware of the derogatory implications of his jest. Or, although a true insult must be intentional, intentions often cannot be ‘proved’. H may evaluate S’s humorous behavior as a disguise of an open insult contained in a witticism with hostile tendencies, and get a vague feeling that the humorous procedure has been abused, in the sense that ‘fair play’ is not the name of the game anymore. However, he/she cannot prove it. S may commit an affront and claim innocence. As Brown and Levinson put it:

“Given the vulnerability of mutual knowledge (the difficulty of ‘knowing’ what is inside anyone else’s head), and the non-recoverability of intonational and kinesic clues, even fairly blatant indirectness may be defensible as innocent – a speaker could protest that he didn’t mean an irony in a sarcastic way, for example. S and H could both go away from the interaction ‘knowing’ in their hearts that it really was sarcastic, but because face (as the word implies) is largely a matter of surface appearances, S may well get away with his Face-Threatening-Act (FTA).” (1978: 217)

3.3. S’s strategic advantages

Assuming that the participants in the interaction strive to gain control over the situation, S (who is the initiator of the humorous act) is in the *a priori* position of a winner and strategically in a more advantageous situation than H. He/she decides on

the suitable circumstances under which he/she can felicitously accomplish this purpose. ‘Getting a laugh’ is a *par excellence* example of controlling the situation according to the ‘balance principle’ (ibid.), which goes as follows:

“If a breach of face respect occurs, this constitutes a kind of debt that must be made up by positive reparation if the original level of face respect is to be maintained.” (Brown and Levinson, 1978: 241)

When laughing, H actually cedes his right to demand satisfaction from S on account of the humorous FTA posed to him.

The following are some of the strategies that are at S’s disposal.

3.3.1. *Saving face insurance*

S’s first strategy for minimizing the threat to his face in case his joke ‘falls flat’ may be to announce ahead where he had heard it in the first place. Then, the original source becomes partially responsible for the potential fiasco (Greenburg, 1964; Sacks, 1989).

3.3.2. *Manipulating the prefacing devices*

In the humorous act, the speaker benefits from the efficaciousness of speech, as well as and from the innocence of silence, in that he says something without, in fact, accepting the responsibility of having said it (Ducrot, in Dolitsky, 1992). This is possible to a large extent, thanks to a network of prefacing devices which can serve as disclaimers. When administering a humorous FTA, S may secure his/her flanks by asking first: ‘Do you want to hear a joke?’, disclaiming the responsibility for the act when telling the joke to H.

Also, S may announce beforehand that his/her joke carries a face-threatening potential by saying: ‘No offense’, thus depriving H of his legitimate option to claim offense. Cashion et al. (1986) found that forewarning tactics prefacing the joke telling were considered by Ss as impolite, since S communicated the intent to violate H’s negative face. In his book *Jewish Humor*, in the course of quoting jokes about Romanian Jews, Rabbi Telushkin inserts the following remark:

“While retelling such ethnic jokes runs the risk of spreading anti-semitism, the jokes are so absurd that I hope the humor outweighs any possible offense. Anyway, I ask my Romanian-Jewish friends in advance for forgiveness.” (1992: 102)

Some of the phrases prefacing the telling of a joke serve as conventional utterances rather than requests for information. They keep the appearance of letting H have his/her turn (e.g. by asking: ‘Have you heard this one ...?’), namely, they pretend to allow H to gain control over the situation, whereas actually S does not cede his domination for a moment. ‘Have you heard this one ...’ is in fact a password, communicating that a joke is to follow; however, it leaves no room for H to answer, because he cannot know whether he heard the joke or not, as long as he is not told what he was supposed to have heard. And once he is told – he has already been told! This has been taken to extremes by Ben-Amotz:

“You must have heard the one about the Jew who comes to Haifa port trying to smuggle two sacks of coffee and when they ask him, ‘What’ve you got in the sacks?’ he says, ‘Bird feed’. And when they ask him, ‘Since when do birds eat coffee?’ he says, ‘They’ll eat if they want; if they don’t, they won’t.’ Don’t you know that one? Okay, so listen: There was this Jew at Haifa port with two sacks of coffee ...” (1981: 133)

The above sequence refers to ways in which S can manipulate the situation. Of course, S may, if he/she so wishes, voluntarily give up his/her dominance over the situation and let H have his/her turn, as in:

S: Have you heard the one about the string that walks in a bar?

H: That’s an old one.

or:

S: Do you want to hear a joke?

H: This is no time for jokes. (Sacks, 1989)

Still, it is up to S to decide whether he or she chooses this course of action.

3.3.3. *The third party*

The third party assisting the humorous enterprise may become an inadvertent strategic ally for S. The course of action in two-party conversation is very different from that in which the third party is present (Sacks, 1989; Glenn, 1989). The acknowledged presence of a third party in the humorous act that initially takes place between two participants increases the potential threat to face for H and consequently increases S’s pay-offs, in that the third party plays the role of intensifier. This party’s presence may seem to intensify S’s risk as well, in that if there were to be a disagreement on humor appreciation between S and H, the third party might serve as a referee. However, this seems to be rather a deceptive assumption. More often than not, the very presence of a third party intensifies the uncertainty of the situation, and H, being unsure as to the third party’s stand on the issue, may prefer to save face by faking amusement against his or her better judgment and allow the FTA to pass for humor rather than admit open offense.

Sometimes a third party is present when a two-party conversation takes place. According to the postulate of negative politeness, the third party is expected to feign his/her non-existence in the room. However, if the interaction is humorous, the third party can hardly pretend not to have overheard it, because spontaneous laughter can hardly be suppressed, and even concealing a sudden smile requires a great deal of self-control. Thus, in the two-party humorous interaction the third party becomes an active participant in transgressing against the etiquette postulates, and plays again into S’s hands, as ‘getting a laugh’ is interpreted as a sign of his/her control of the situation.

3.4. *H’s countermoves*

The most successful circumstances for performing the humorous FTA – as for any other humorous act – are when it is possible to take H by surprise, i.e. without pref-

acing devices. When H is not prepared for the punch-line that is to come, there is practically no time left to perform the switch from BF to BF(H) mode; the switch has to be performed retroactively. H may refuse to do this, and take offense; but then it is too late for S to call off the whole thing, the humorous FTA already having been delivered. It may seem for a moment that at this point H regains control, but then, again, S has his/her regression lines. He/she may say: 'It was a just a joke', implying H's failure to switch to the correct mode. Or he/she may say: 'I didn't mean it', implying H's failure to decode his/her (i.e. S's) intention. S may also ask, unbelievably: 'Don't you have any sense of humor?', thus aggressively questioning H's cognitive capabilities (Sherzer, 1985). All these escapes of S are additional non-humorous FTAs to H's positive and negative faces. It is as if S is in a no-lose situation; consequently H is in a no-win situation. Of course, H may try to regain control by calling all the bets off, announcing BF mode without redress, as in:

S: It was a joke.

H: And a very bad one too!

or:

S: I didn't mean it.

H: Apology accepted.

or:

S: Don't you have any sense of humor?

H: Yours is indeed very peculiar.

In these cases, the energy which could otherwise be let out in a burst of laughter, is channeled to making amends and clarifications. However, this course of action is a Pyrrhic victory for H. On the other hand, H may also react aggressively, and do damage to S's face, for example. In this case, H also breaks the conventions of politeness; H's behavior is therefore not within the scope of this paper.

Yet, there is a way for H to turn the tables, regain control over the situation, and recover the pay-off tokens from S. This can be effected by applying counterhumor. Such a situation was described by Richard Feynman, the Nobel prizewinner scientist, who conducted a logical debate with Jewish students, hoping to trap them, himself being armed with Jewish nitpicking logic:

"And do you know what happened? They're rabbinical students, right? They were ten times better than I was! As soon as they saw I could put them in a hole, they went twist, turn, twist – I can't remember how – and they were free! I thought I had come up with an original idea – phooey! It had been discussed in the Talmud for ages. So they cleaned me up just as easy as pie – they got right out." (Feynman and Leighton, 1985: 260)

In a way, applying counterhumor turns the personal insult into what may resemble the 'sounding' exchange described by Labov (1972) within the context of Black English Vernacular, thus diminishing the face threat potential. The former dyadic

interaction which included an insult (I) and a denial or excuse (D), (or: humorous FTA – non-humorous response), turns sequential (humor–counterhumor),

“... since a sound and its response are essentially the same kind of thing, and a response calls for a further response.” (Labov, 1972: 152)

and also because:

“The skill of the sounder leaves the ultimate decision up to the challenger: if he insists on taking the matter personally the fight will go on, but he has already condemned himself and will find it very hard to regain his lost ground.” (ibid.: 168)

3.5. Strategic advantages of self-denigrating humor

Paradoxical as it may sound, it seems that one of S's biggest strategical pay-offs can be found in using self-denigrating humor. The phenomenon of humor directed against one's self has been especially interesting to psychologists. The fact that someone may choose to humiliate him/herself in the presence of others seemed very peculiar to them. Such self-disparagement has been widely assigned to Jewish people, which has led some researchers to attribute masochism to the Jewish nation:

“Yet the assumption of an intensive self-humiliating and self-degrading tendency in Jewish wit is correct. It is not important whether we call it masochistic or pseudo-masochistic ...” (Reik, 1962: 226)

As mentioned before, the extent to which an FTA is taken for an offense depends on S's intentions. If no additional evidence of S's hostility towards H is given, the FTA may be interpreted as humorous. It is assumed that nobody in his/her right mind is hostile towards him/herself. Therefore, when a self-denigrating FTA is performed, this is interpreted as humorous, and cognitive consistence remains preserved. Allport (1958) says that ethnic minorities, for example Jews or Blacks, use self-denigrating humor in which they belittle themselves and mock their own group, tradition, language and religion, in order to appease the ruling majority. Their pay-off is assumed to be in the presentation of an appealing self-image, as well as in achieving material gains or professional fame as successful comedians. Another psychological pay-off derived from this interpretation may be that the apparent self-denigration is misleading, and anybody who believes it actually becomes himself the butt of the joke played on him. Ziv describes the following pay-offs to the user of self-disparaging humor:

“One message of self-disparaging humor to the enemy could ... run something like this: ‘You don't have to attack me and damage my honor – I'll do it myself (and even better than you!)’. In addition, the enemy's laugh may discharge his hostility, so that he does not use his weapon. It is better to look scared, miserly, and foolish, and to stay alive, than it is to die.” (1984: 111)

An S making use of humor directed against him/herself is usually taken for a courageous person, not afraid to publicly uncover his or her own weaknesses (which often reflect similar flaws in H's character). In S's self-denigration H may see a representation of his/her own fears, and admire S's way of coping with them by admit-

ting, rather than denying, their existence. The user of self-directed humor seems not to be afraid to lose face. He/she evokes mixed feelings towards him/herself: pity, sympathy, appreciation, and love. H does not feel threatened by such a person, on the contrary, H may experience the soothing feeling of superiority over the *schlemiel*.

Paradoxically, the apparent inferiority presented by S who is engaged in self-directed humor may also bear a message of superiority. By mentioning his/her weakness, he may give the impression that this is his/her only weakness, along the lines: 'I'm not afraid to mention my faults. If I mention only one, it means there are no others. Otherwise I would have specified them also'. Of course.

The user of self-directed humor presents him/herself as having insight and being critical of him/herself, so that he/she is not likely to be too disappointed. When another person laughs at you, you are helpless. When you laugh at yourself, you are in control of the situation and it is up to you to tighten, to loosen, or to let go at any given moment. An S who attacks himself leaves his audience bewildered: does he mean what he says or does he not? As a matter of fact, from a self-denigrating humor display H cannot know for sure what S really thinks of himself. In this way, self-directed humor may serve to set boundaries, contrary to the popular belief that its use allows for shortening the psychological distance between the participants.

As mentioned before, the humorous mode can be regarded as a 'covering move' which *aims* at being uncovered (Zajdman, 1992). Similarly, self-directed humor bears a circular message: 'I am weak. I admit it. To admit means to be strong. So, I am strong'. H's laughter conveys his cognitive bewilderment. Is S weak or strong, and to what extent? Only S knows the answer and he will make use of it in a moment best suitable to his plans and purposes. So, the self-directed humor which seems to bravely *expose* S's weaknesses, actually helps to cunningly *conceal* S's strengths. In this lies its enormous strategic advantage.

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